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Rasa Theory and AI Art

Introduction

Art is notoriously difficult to define, but a central unifying feature of much art is the capacity to communicate emotion; by expressing the private emotions of an artist, art evokes some related emotion in the spectator. This rich process of communication is the focus of rasa theory. This essay argues that rasa theory uniquely identifies what AI-generated art lacks because rasa requires a double translation between particular and general experience, and AI degenerates the artist's half of that translation. This does not entail that AI output cannot please, only that AI art belongs in a fundamentally different category from art on account of its means of production. The essay first presents rasa theory, especially its views on the aesthetic necessity of generalization; then, it analyzes the communicative process of art through a framework of double translation; finally, it applies that framework to AI art as a unique test case in order to demonstrate the strength of rasa theory as a theory of aesthetic experience in art.

Rasa Theory

Rasa theory was first formulated in the sixth chapter of Bharata's *Treatise on Drama* to delineate the difference between drama and ordinary life (Haberman 1988: 13). Just as mixing ingredients in prescribed ratios gives rise to pleasant taste, Bharata argues that rasa, or the analogous aesthetic taste of drama, arises as the amalgamation of causes (*vibhāva*), effects

(*anubhāva*), and transitory emotions (*vyabhicāri-bhāva*) that intensify a stable emotion (*sthāyī-bhāva*). This aestheticized emotion is precisely what separates drama from ordinary life (Pollock 2016: 51). Importantly, Bharata's goal is only to identify this difference, which he does objectively, and not from the experiential perspective of the spectator.

This experiential perspective is first considered by Bhaṭṭa Nāyaka. In particular, he asks why all art is enjoyable for the spectator, even when it ostensibly depicts negative circumstances and seems to evoke correspondingly negative emotions. The crux of his answer lies in the concept of generalization (*sādhāraṇī-karaṇa*), the process by which the spectator's personal emotion transcends to the aestheticized emotion that is the true entity communicated by the art (Haberman 1988: 17). When one watches a tragedy, one experiences emotional intensity but is aware that the events of the tragedy have no consequence on one's personal life. Because of this disconnection, one is free to appreciate the aesthetic beauty of the emotion independent from the consequences of the circumstances that give rise to it.

Abhinavagupta goes further: the key to aesthetic pleasure, he argues, is to remove obstacles associated with the individual, allowing the spectator to achieve a transcendent state reminiscent of that of the mystic, in which one is completely free from individual concerns and therefore free to identify fully with artistic circumstances (Haberman 1988: 20). In this view, *rasa* is located only in the spectator, not in the actor or the character, as only the spectator can enter this transcendent state (Haberman 1988: 24).

The Double Translation

Generalization has so far been presented as a process occurring on the side of the spectator alone. This essay argues that generalization is better understood as a structural feature of the entire artistic transaction. In fact, *rasa* theory implicitly requires a double translation between the

individual and the general, occurring first on the part of the artist, as the art is being created, and again on the part of the audience, as the art is being perceived.

All artistic content originates in the artist's individual experience; there is no other possible source for it. From that point, for all art that is not purely autobiographical, the content must then pass through a medium of generalizability in which the artist abstracts from the particular case of their own experiences, identifies features capable of being shared, and re-particularizes them into a new individual situation as, for instance, the plot of a drama. The audience reverses the path: encountering the work's particulars, they recognize generalized features, which they connect to their own stored experiences and impressions of those experiences. In summary, the content moves from individual to general to individual on the part of the artist, and then from individual to general to individual on the part of the audience.

The AI Test Case

Consider AI-generated art. Generative models are trained on completed works, which means the artist's half of the translative process is entirely circumvented. The result is generalized form expressed in a particular result—after all, the output is a single work—but this result has no individual experiential origin. As a consequence, the double translation collapses into a single translation on the part of the audience.

This passage was generated by the AI chatbot Claude:

The window held the last light like something it was reluctant to give back. She watched the dust move through it, the way it always moved when the house was empty, and she thought about her mother's hands — how they had been quick, once, and then slower, and then still. There was nothing to be done about any of it. The kettle began its small complaint on the stove.

This passage may be evocative to some readers, and it is in some ways technically well-written, deploying literary devices praised by rasa theory. But this is only mimicry; it suggests nothing because the words were not written with the intent to describe anything in particular. They were written without any particular mother or any particular hands in mind. The grief belongs to no one, even if the model was trained on works written by authors who did experience particular grief.

This argument also finds support in the texts. Bhaṭṭa Nāyaka's concept of generalization presupposes that what is generalized was once particular: one cannot generalize what was never individual. Similarly, Abhinavagupta's argument about removing obstacles on the audience side implies symmetry on the producing side: for the spectator to access the generalized emotions inherent in the work, the artist must first have somehow installed those generalized emotions there, which requires a prior generalization from the artist's own particular experience. The spectator-locus argument does not contradict this: rasa is experienced only by the spectator, but the material for rasa is generalized human experience, and the artist is the source of that material. Translation from the general by the audience presupposes the prior existence of an emotion that has already been generalized by an artist.

It might be argued that this last fact is precisely what saves AI art: the generalized human emotion of the training corpus is still present in the output, even if it has been diffused, so the artist's translation has still been performed to an extent. This objection misunderstands what generalization is in rasa theory. Generalization here does not refer to a statistically driven aggregation of patterns but an act of an experiencing subject who abstracts features from experiences because those specific features matter to them. The grief in the passage above is

entirely a creation of the reader: the text evokes grief only because the reader matches the words to their own particular experiences.

Rasa Theory as a General Theory

If this is right, the AI test case demonstrates the strength of rasa theory. Reader-response theory, which locates aesthetic value in the reader's response, would deem AI art aesthetically successful as long as readers respond, entirely missing the distinction between art and AI art. Formalism, which locates aesthetic value in the features of the work, would deem AI art successful whenever it has the right features, suffers the same fate. Rasa theory, in contrast, identifies the artistic deficiency of AI art directly through its lack of an individual experience on the part of an artist that is capable of being generalized.

It is tempting to conclude that AI art transcends even rasa theory's transcendence: having no ego, it removes more obstacles. However, this inverts Abhinavagupta's argument. The obstacles he wants removed are those of the spectator, not those of the work. Works do not have such egos in the relevant sense; characters have egos, but these contribute to the causes, one of the components of rasa, and so help produce rasa rather than impede it. Moreover, by Abhinavagupta's account, the spectator's freedom from ego presupposes something to identify with, namely generalized emotion installed in the work by an artist.

Rasa theory is a theory of art specifically, not of all aesthetic experience; it is a theory of the savoring of generalized human emotion that has been particularized by a particular experiencing subject. Sunsets are aesthetically powerful but are not art, and AI output may be aesthetically powerful in this same non-artistic way, as a kind of found object. Therefore, to say that AI art lacks rasa is not to say that it lacks aesthetic value altogether, but to say that whatever aesthetic value it has belongs to a category outside the realm of art. Rasa theory's strength is that

it identifies which category an object belongs to and identifies the fundamental difference between the impersonal beauty of AI art and the communicative beauty of art.

Conclusion

Rasa theory succeeds as a theory of literature and drama because it specifies the structural conditions for one important kind of aesthetic experience, a capacity that is tested by considering AI art. The double translation between individual and general is not a contingent feature of how human art happens to work; on rasa theory's account, it is what art is. What moves us about AI art is either the recognition of our own stored impressions in a work that imitates art, or the impersonal found beauty of an entity outside the category of art altogether. Rasa theory does not deny the second possibility; it simply distinguishes it from the first. That the theory makes this distinction available, even when applied to a contemporary case its originators could not have anticipated, is a testament to its strength as an account of what art is and what it does.

References

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